By design, only wood-to-wood glue joints using the bamboo rod to bond all of the blackwood pieces

For shell to wood bonding, I use minimal glue interface with epoxy adhesive

Contouring the wooden interfaces to follow the curves of the shell, place a small amount of adhesive in the centre

Hanging ornaments

The season where ornaments are big has passed but it isn't too soon to begin making next year's. The types of ornaments really is limited only to your imagination. Whether hanging or standing, you have many options to factor into your creations. In the hanging ornament category, the ever popular 'birdhouse' ornament can have the roof shaped, adorned or not, as you wish with a shell body. You need not be an artist to create some very interesting ornaments. The shells can be spray painted alone or have some craft store self-adhesive appliqués applied for interest. The assortment of available appliqués is huge and they are very inexpensive. A simple spray painting with contrasting colour swipes draws attention as does easily done pyrographed shingle roofs. Hanging ornaments can also include the upper finial, body and lower finial styles whether pierced or not. When turning your finials, dense species such as African blackwood (*Dalbergia melanoxylon*) will give you a dark colour naturally and hold exquisite detail. In the past, I've experimented with other species and tried to colour it black but have never been completely satisfied. I find that blackwood, despite its pricing, fits the bill and is worth seeking out. Of course, the grain needs to be straight for strong, delicate finials. Any figure or off-axis grain is a potential failure point once you've turned thin.

Piercing allows for internally placed items to be featured such as this candelabra-shaped earring

A painted chicken eggshell with pyrographed and dyed cherry roof with a paper bird on a perch is easily made

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